"Who's your favorite pony?": An Analysis of My Little Pony Demographics Regarding Their Favorite Pony and Consumer Engagement Profiles

Work by:

Astibe, Juliana Eunice A.

Bachelor of Science in Information Technology Student from

The Polytechnic University of the Philippines

Main Campus

2026

Table of Contents

Introduction 1

Problem Statement 2

Objectives 2

General Objective 2

Specific Objectives 3

Dataset Description 3

Methodology 4

Data Cleaning Process 6

Data Analysis and Computations 7

Visualizations 9

Findings and Insights 14

The Process and Value of Independence Testing 14

Statistical Outputs for Demographic Factors 14

Financial Engagement and Variance Modeling 15

Consumer Archetype and Market Profiling 16

Conclusion 17

Recommendations 18

References 20

1.0 Introduction

The My Little Pony franchise was started in 1981, debuting as a toy line named “My Pretty Pony” under the American toy company Hasbro. The official My Little Pony toy line followed shortly after, running globally from 1982 until 1995. Driven by growing popularity, these toys were adapted into animated TV specials and feature-length films, marking what is now known as Generation 1 (G1) of the franchise.

Generation 2 saw a decline in commercial success. After entering the toy industry in 1997, the line quickly disappeared from U.S. shelves by 1999 and received little to no media (The Zay Zay Zone, 2025). Consequently, the franchise underwent a revamp for Generation 3, which targeted a younger audience and utilized direct-to-video animated films to support the toy line. This strategy restored commercial momentum, paving the way for the most beloved era in the franchise's history: Generation 4 (G4). Launched in 2010 and initially directed by Lauren Faust, My Little Pony: Friendship Is Magic captured a massive, diverse fandom of self-proclaimed "Bronies" and "Pegasisters".

This unprecedented success can be credited to a major narrative shift: the franchise moved away from human protagonists, placing the ponies themselves as the central leads. By giving the characters complex personalities and relatable adventures, the show resonated deeply with audiences well beyond its original child demographic, inspiring fans to choose distinct personal favorites. Culturally and financially, the brand exploded; it grossed over $650 million in retail sales in 2013, and surpassed $1 billion annually in both 2014 (Hasbro, 2015) and 2015.

Although the Friendship Is Magic series concluded in 2021 and was followed by Generation 5 (My Little Pony: A New Generation), G4 remains uniquely memorable to fans. Global retail chains like Miniso and trading card brands like Kayou continue to produce and distribute G4 merchandise, which has become highly collectible and tradable. To sustain and build upon the brand's enduring commercial success, analyzing target consumer demographics and character favorability is of utmost importance, ensuring that product supply matches demand and that no fans are left without merchandise of their favorite ponies.

2.0 Problem Statement

Hasbro has found massive commercial success with its My Little Pony: Friendship Is Magic series, fostering a deeply dedicated fandom that heavily engages in merchandise collection. Over the years, the franchise's consumer base has undergone a dramatic demographic shift, expanding from its original target audience of young girls to a diverse global community spanning all ages, geographic locations, and gender identities.

Understanding the alignment between specific character preferences and distinct demographic segments is critical for driving targeted marketing, product design, and inventory distribution. Misjudging which characters appeal to high-spending segments versus casual consumers can lead to missed revenue or dead inventory. With this, this project aims to answer the following questions:

1. What characters from My Little Pony: Friendship is Magic are the most favored among the fanbase?
2. Does character favorability significantly differ across age groups and gender identities?
3. What demographic profiles of My Little Pony: Friendship is Magic does the fanbase consist of?
4. How do distinct fan segments (e.g., Bronies vs. Casual Fans) differ in their annual financial investment in merchandise?
5. How can disparate, noisy, and inconsistent consumer survey responses be effectively cleaned and standardized to ensure reliable market analysis?

3.0 Objectives

General Objective

The main goal of this study is to clean, process, and analyze a market franchise survey dataset for My Little Pony: Friendship is Magic (G4) using R to recognize and map fan favorites against consumer demographics and their financial merchandise engagement.

Specific Objectives

To achieve this general objective, the study will address the following specific technical and analytical goals:

- Implement data cleaning and standardization to accurately analyze the dataset and remove any data anomalies.
- Determine which specific characters outside of and including the "Mane 6" hold the highest bias or popularity percentages across the collective fanbase.
- Analyze the shift of character favorability across different consumer attributes such as age, gender, and geographic location.
- Quantify the annual financial investment associated with distinct fan segments or categories to determine which sub-fandoms have higher commercial value.
- Translate demographic and favorability insights to visual graphs and metrics useful in product decision-making.

4.0 Dataset Description

The dataset used in this study was simulated by Gemini AI and does not reflect any real-world survey. All attributes here are useful in analyzing favorite ponies and consumer profiles. It was designed to have typographical errors and duplicate records, as well as wrong, invalid, or missing values for the data cleaning process.

Attribute Name	Data Type	Variable Type	Description
Respondent_ID	character	nominal	The unique identifiers for each respondent
Age	double	ratio	The numerical age of the respondents
Gender	character	nominal	Categorical demographic marker for gender
Favorite_Pony	character	nominal	Encompasses the standard Mane 6 as well as fan favorites outside the main group

Fan_Segment	character	ordinal	Categorical profiling that identifies the consumer archetype
Annual_Spend_USD	double	ratio	The continuous numerical metric representing financial investment in franchise merchandise
Country	character	nominal	The geographic location of the respondent

Table 1. Dataset Description

The dataset comprises 1,545 records and 7 columns. Table 1 outlines the current data types assigned to each column, which may differ from their ideal configurations. For instance, the Age variable is currently stored as a double, but it should be modified to an integer since age values do not require decimal precision.

Considering the problem statements and objectives, the variables here all serve a purpose in the dataset in gathering critical insights for the analysis.

5.0 Methodology

The initial stage of the study involves environment initialization by loading requisite R libraries, specifically the tidyverse suite, to utilize dplyr for data manipulation. Following the establishment of the workspace, the simulated market survey CSV is imported into the RStudio environment. A preliminary diagnostic examination is then conducted using foundational functions such as *glimpse()* and *summary()* to inspect the structural integrity and layout of the raw dataset. This critical assessment facilitates the identification of latent data anomalies requiring fixing, including duplicate records, extreme numerical outliers, or inconsistent formatting.

Upon identification of these discrepancies, a rigorous data cleaning process is implemented to standardize the dataset. This phase addresses the identified flaws by first purging explicit duplicate entries to preserve analytical integrity. Categorical attributes are managed by recoding missing values into a distinct “Other” category, thereby retaining data volume while ensuring clarity. Furthermore, typographical errors and non-uniform character casing within the gender and character preference columns are recoded into a singular, standardized format.

Numerical inconsistencies are further refined by filtering the age variable to exclude improbable values (i.e., negative values) and converting the data type from double to integer for precision. To address missing financial metrics without compromising the overall distribution, null values in the annual merchandise investment column are resolved through grouped mean imputation. Utilizing the *coalesce()* function, the process dynamically populates missing entries with the calculated mean specific to each fan segment, ensuring that financial engagement profiles remain representative.

Now that the dataset is completely cleaned and ready, the next step is to perform statistical computations to find useful insights. This part focuses on counting the main demographics and checking how character preferences change across different groups in the fanbase. At the same time, statistical tests and grouping methods are used to see if different types of fans have different spending habits. By looking at the data this way, these calculations help group the survey responses into clear customer profiles that directly answer the project's main problems and objectives. These statistics provide the framework for the visualization phase, wherein ggplot2 is utilized to generate high-fidelity charts and graphs.

By illustrating the percentage distribution of favorite ponies and cross-tabulating character favorability against age demographics, the visualizations effectively map complex consumer patterns. This synthesis of visual and mathematical evidence informs the final analysis and conclusion, where character biases and demographic shifts are interpreted. The resulting insights facilitate the delivery of actionable recommendations to optimize brand strategy and merchandise distribution for the franchise.

6.0 Data Cleaning Process

The cleaning process begins by running a quick diagnostic glimpse and summary of the data frame to locate structural inconsistencies. Next, duplicate records are identified by tracking exactly what and where the repeated rows are. Once located, these duplicate records are removed from the dataset to ensure every survey entry is entirely unique.

Data types are then adjusted for consistent analysis. The Age column is converted from a double (decimal) to a clean integer format. Categorical inputs are transformed into factors and standardized to eliminate messy formatting; various text cases like "M" or "male" are unified into a singular "Male" format, with a matching rule applied to females.

The Favorite_Pony column is converted to a factor while fixing typos, misspellings, and mixed letter cases into singular, uniform names. For Fan_Segment, the column is transformed into an ordered factor, manually mapping levels from lowest engagement (General Public) to highest engagement (Brony) to help evaluate consumption patterns. Finally, Country is made a factor, and an explicit level for "Other" is introduced to accommodate missing values.

The next step involves filtering the dataset to see exactly what and where the remaining missing values reside. To address these gaps safely, missing cells in the Gender and Country columns are filled with the placeholder string "Other". Numerical constraints are also applied here, limiting the valid Age range to individuals strictly greater than 0 and less than 100 years old.

Rows are completely dropped if they lack a Favorite_Pony or a Respondent_ID, as these core entries cannot be left blank. To handle missing values in Annual_Spend_USD without skewing the data, the remaining rows are grouped by Fan_Segment. The mathematical mean of each individual segment is calculated by omitting existing missing parameters, used to fill the blank spaces, and the dataframe is ultimately ungrouped.

In the final step, the fully processed data frame is loaded using a view or summary function. This allows for a final manual double-check to confirm that all dimensions, metrics, and categories are properly aligned before diving into visualizations.

7.0 Data Analysis and Computations

First, the total count and frequency percentages of gender and favorite pony choices were calculated to map out the baseline demographics of the dataset. For age-related calculations, raw numerical ages were grouped into specific categorical brackets (Child, Teenager, Young Adult, and Adult) to make the data cleaner and easier to analyze.

Chi-square (χ^2) formula:

$$\chi^2 = \Sigma \frac{(O-E)^2}{E}$$

Where:

- χ^2 is the chi-square test statistic
- Σ is the summation operator
- O is the observed frequency
- E is the expected frequency

Cramér's V formula:

$$V = \sqrt{\frac{\chi^2}{N \times min(c-1, r-1)}}$$

Where:

- V is the Cramér's V correlation coefficient
- χ^2 is the test statistic derived from the Chi-square test of independence
- N is the total sample size (total number of records in the dataset)
- c is the total number of columns in the contingency table
- r is the total number of rows in the contingency table
- $min(c-1, r-1)$ is the minimum value between the total number of columns minus one, and the total number of rows minus one

To test if a person's favorite pony depends on their age category, gender, or country, individual Pearson's Chi-squared tests for categorical data (χ^2) were performed. Following the Chi-square tests, Cramér's V was calculated to measure the actual strength of these associations on a scale between 0 and 1. A value of 0 means absolutely no association, while 1 indicates a perfect association. Because Cramér's V serves as an effect size metric, it helps determine if a statistically significant result is practically meaningful or just minor dataset noise.

One-Way ANOVA formula:

$$F = \frac{MS_{between}}{MS_{within}}$$

Where:

- F is the ANOVA test statistic
- $MS_{between}$ is the Mean Square between groups (measures variance due to the different fan segments)
- MS_{within} is the Mean Square within groups (measures the internal variance or error within the groups)

Tukey's HSD Formula:

$$HSD = q\sqrt{\frac{MS_{within}}{n}}$$

Where:

- HSD is the Honest Significant Difference value (the minimum difference needed between two group means to be considered statistically significant)
- q is the studentized range statistic (obtained from a standard Tukey lookup table based on your degrees of freedom and total groups)
- MS_{within} is the Mean Square within groups derived from the ANOVA model
- n is the sample size per group (or the harmonic mean of the sample sizes if the groups are unequal)

For the financial data, a one-way Analysis of Variance (ANOVA) was executed to check if there is any relevance in comparing annual merchandise spending across different fan segments. This test evaluates the overall variance between groups; if no spending differences exist, the results would simply retain the null hypothesis. Finally, because a significant ANOVA score only proves that a gap exists somewhere in the data, Tukey's Honest Significant Difference (HSD) post-hoc test was applied. By comparing the adjusted p-values against the alpha threshold ($p < 0.05$), this calculation isolates exactly which specific fan groups have major financial differences between them.

8.0 Visualizations

With the needed data cleaned and computed, visualization is next. Despite it being optional to some, it actually helps illustrate the data further and give life. Instead of looking at tables, data can be understood even by a glance. For this project, the visualizations (using ggplot2) are designed to illustrate the relationships between consumer demographics, character preferences, and financial engagement, effectively transforming raw statistical output into actionable strategic insights for the brand.

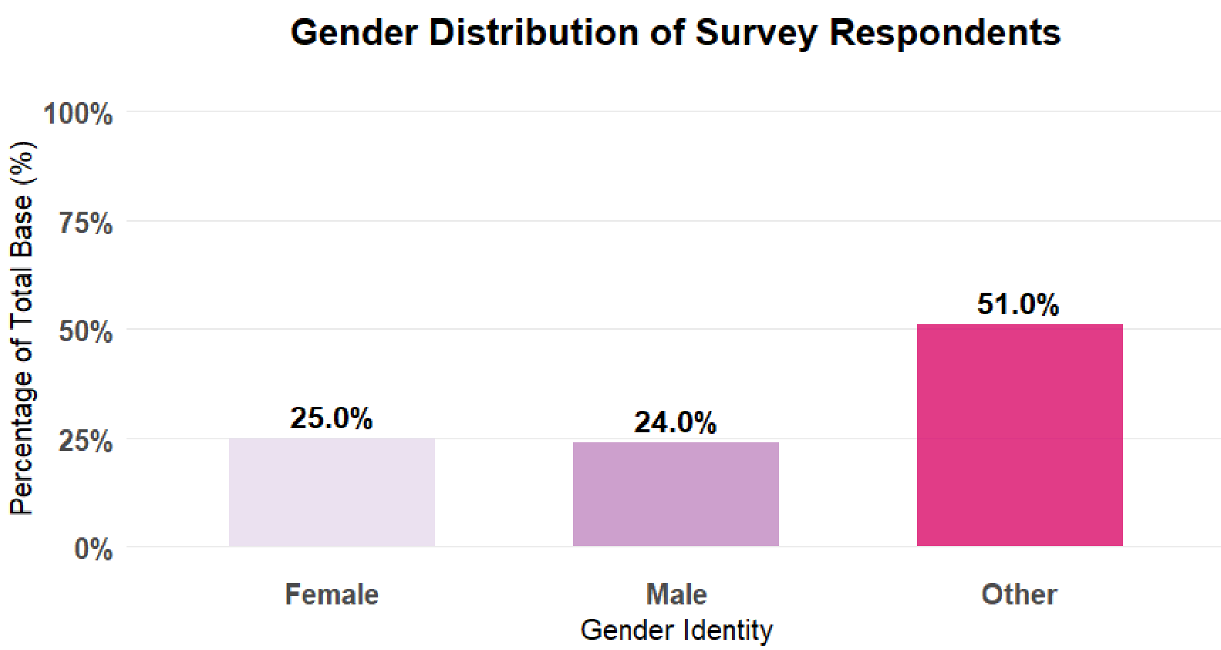

Figure 1. Gender Distribution

Before cleaning, the dataset included a wider range of gender categories, such as non-binary, "prefer not to say," and missing values. After cleaning, these were grouped into an "Other" category. This is significant, as the graph shows that 51.0% of respondents fall under this classification, suggesting this grouping may not fully capture the diversity of the original responses. Additionally, the proportion of female respondents is only 1% higher than that of male respondents, a difference that may be statistically negligible.

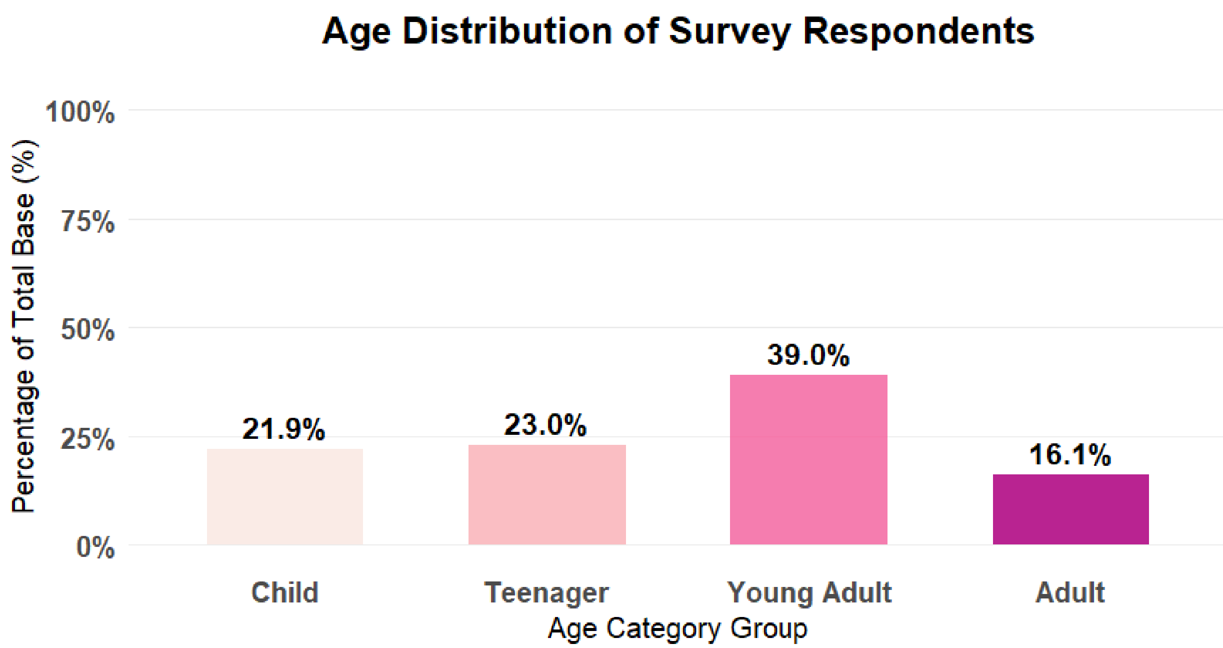

Figure 2. Age Distribution

Upon categorizing the respondents by age, young adults (20–30 years old) emerged as the leading demographic, comprising 39% of the survey responses. The next largest group consists of teenagers (13–19 years old) at approximately 23%, followed by children (under 13) at 21.9%. The remaining respondents fall into the 31 and above age bracket.

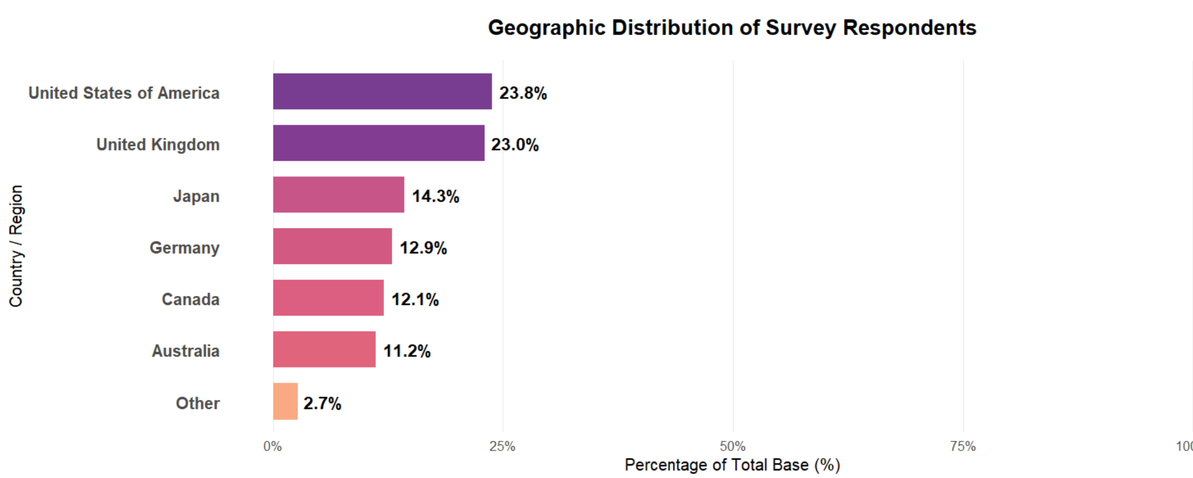

Figure 3. Geographic Distribution

The data indicates that the United States of America comprises the largest portion of survey respondents at 23.8%, suggesting that this region likely represents the primary consumer base for the franchise. This finding aligns with data from the World Population Review (2026), which ranks the U.S. as the leading global nation in consumer spending, supporting the validity of these results. The United Kingdom follows as the second-largest group in the survey, trailing by only 0.8%. Notably, the "Other" category encompasses missing or unspecified responses; as these could originate from any country, the geographic results should be interpreted with awareness of this potential skew.

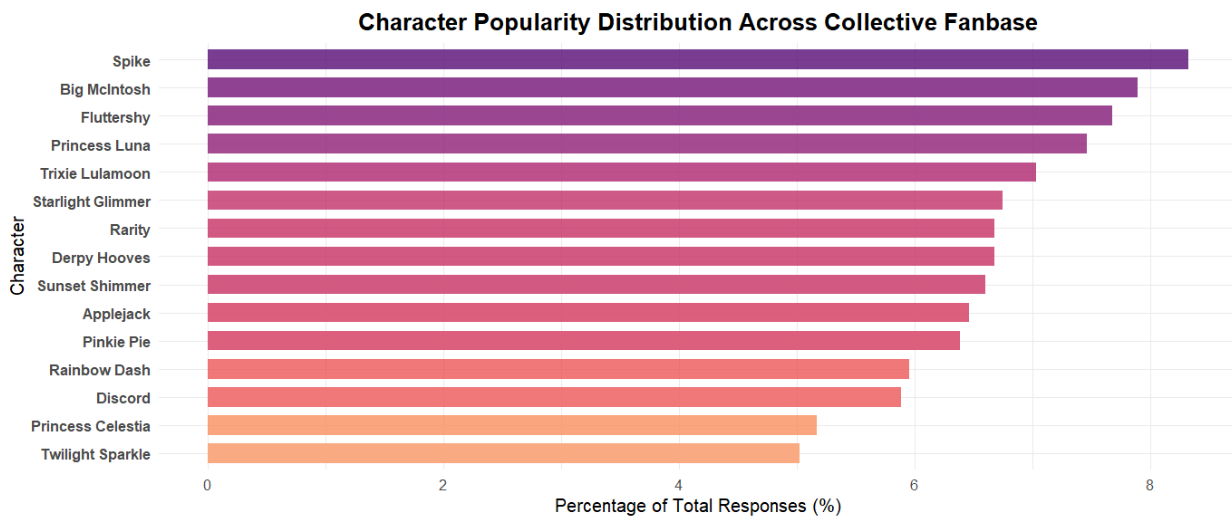

Figure 4. Character Popularity

While the initial design phase considered utilizing a pie chart for visualization, further assessment revealed that the high cardinality of character preferences would result in significant visual compression and reduced readability. Given that circular charts are optimally constrained to five categories or fewer, a bar graph was determined to be a more effective analytical tool for presenting the relative distribution of favorite ponies.

In total, after data cleaning, there were a total of 15 ponies that were chosen as someone's favorite. The most favored character being Spike the Dragon, appearing even in older generations of My Little Pony, which can be a factor. Despite being the main character, Twilight Sparkle here ranks last in the list of people's favorite ponies. This however does not mean that she is the least favorite among all characters in the series since, as mentioned, this is only from the 15 characters answered in the survey.

This poses an interesting discussion as often times in media, the main characters are less liked in the fanbase compared to the side characters. Under a subreddit in r/writing, Correct-Shoulder-147 (2026) mentioned that main characters are often a narrative device whereas the side characters are more free to write, giving them more nuance. Characters like Big Mac and Trixie do not have major roles in the world but they are given their own personalities that people seem to be drawn to. Additionally, characters like Derpy Hooves are special as they were background ponies that weren't meant to be noticed at first. Derpy's cross-eyed appearance was just an animation error kept in but had a huge mark in the fanbase.

Also noteworthy are the "redemption" ponies, such as Starlight and Sunset, who were villains at one point in the series and appear as answers in this survey. The portrayal of their lowest points, motivations, and "negative" emotions, alongside their character growth, has likely resonated with many fans. As no one is flawless, these characters provide the narrative with depth and a message that, with friends by their side, anyone can change for the better.

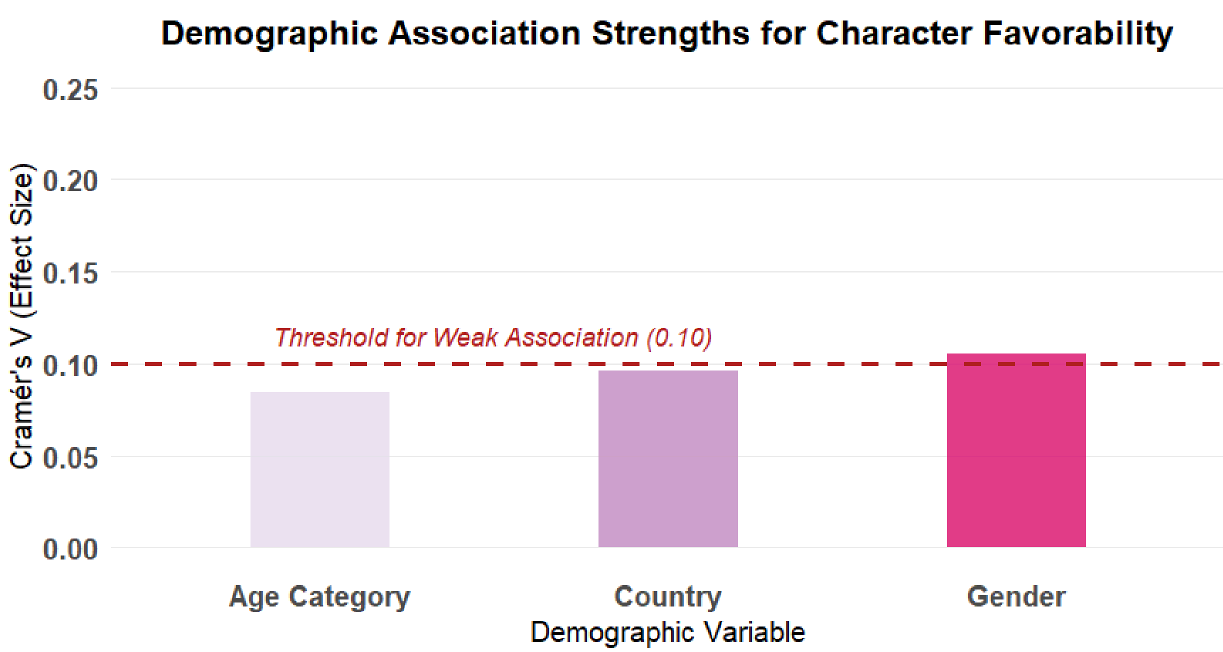

Figure 5. Proof of Independence

Based on Cramér's V, strength of association can be classified as weak (0.10), moderate (0.30), or high (0.50). After taking the Chi-square of favorite ponies to age, country, and gender, the line shows that age and country do not meet the strength needed for a weak association. Gender, however, pushed through the line by a bit. But, as mentioned in the description of Figure 1, the gender shows mostly “other” as the category, which may not be insightful.

Thus, this illustrates that the reason for someone’s favorite pony is independent of one’s age, gender, and country. It may be moreso the relatability they feel for certain characters, aesthetics, or other factors not taken in the survey.

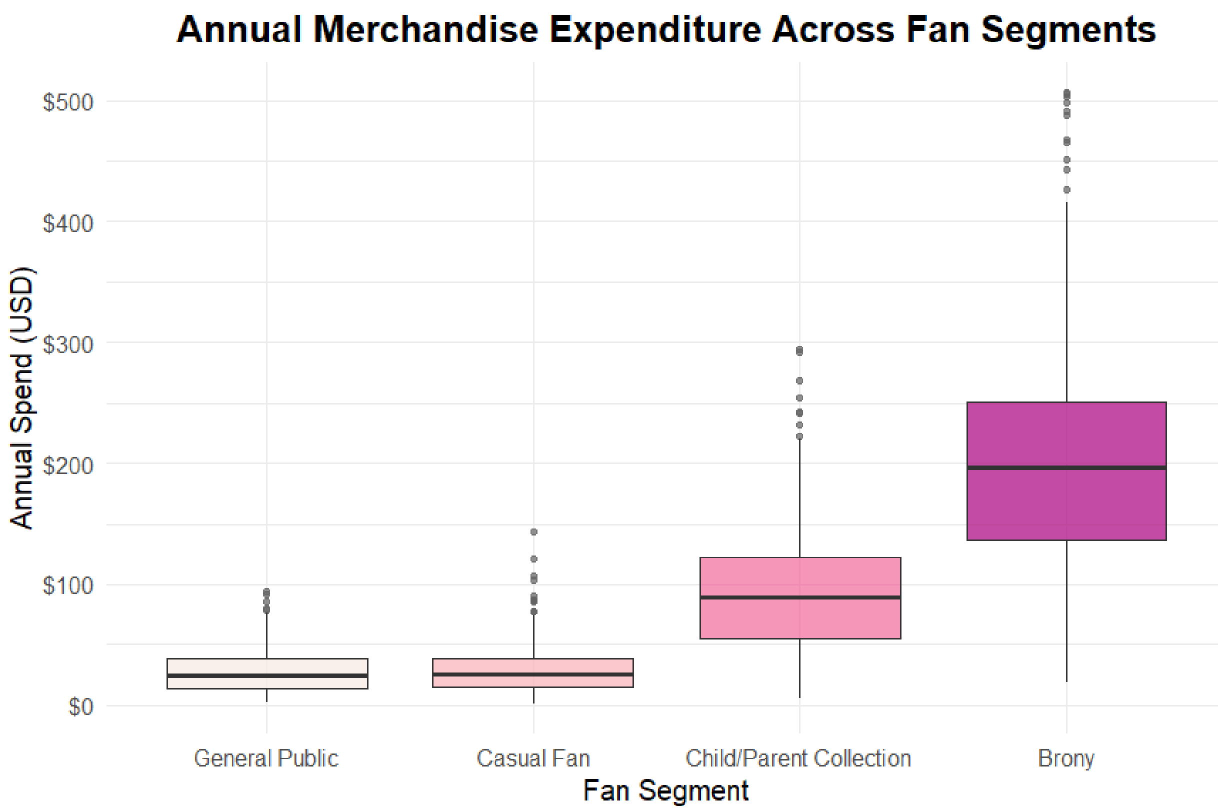

Figure 6. Financial Engagement

This box and whisker plot shows each fan segment’s annual spend for G4 merch. The Brony demographic demonstrates the highest level of financial engagement, with a median of around $200 and a high degree of variability, as indicated by the box’s length, showing diverse spending behaviors within the same fan segment. Furthermore, high-spending outliers stretch up to $500 dollars, cementing this segment as the primary revenue driver. In contrast, the general public and casual fans exhibit low spending and minimal variability, represented by the tightly compressed boxes near the $0–$50 range. The child/parent collection segment occupies a middle ground, showing moderate and varied spending habits that typically peaks at $200, as indicated by the upper whisker.

9.0 Findings and Insights

The Process and Value of Independence Testing

During the initial planning phases, it was challenging to predict whether demographic backgrounds would heavily skew character preferences. Evaluating these relationships using raw data tables or massive visualizations would have resulted in unreadable clutter. Utilizing the *chisq.test()* and *assocstats()* functions from the vcd library proved to be the most efficient method for analyzing these categorical variables.Instead of building massive charts for every single pony across age groups, genders, and countries, the process of running Pearson's Chi-squared tests (χ^2) allowed for an immediate check for statistical relevance across all records. To ensure that minor sample variations were not mistaken for real consumer trends, Cramér's V calculations were introduced as an effect-size metric to measure the actual strength of these relationships on a clean scale between 0 and 1.

Statistical Outputs for Demographic Factors

Age Category: To test if age shifts consumer tastes, a cross-tabulation matrix was evaluated. Using the Ch-squared formula mentioned in Part 7.0, The computation yielded a Pearson chi-square value of 29.843 with 42 degrees of freedom, resulting in a p-value of 0.92026. Because the p-value is significantly higher than the standard 0.05 alpha threshold, the null hypothesis cannot be rejected.

To determine the practical strength of this non-significant result, Cramér's V was calculated. This step resulted in a Cramér's V value of 0.085 (with a Contingency Coefficient of 0.145 and a Phi value of NA due to the table dimension size). A score of 0.085 is extremely close to zero, falling well under the traditional 0.10 threshold line. This provides definitive proof that a person's favorite character is entirely independent of their age bracket.

Country or Geographic Location: A identical testing method was executed to evaluate if geographic placement or regional cultures impacted character selection. The baseline Chi-squared test generated a value of 76.642 with 84 degrees of freedom, producing a p-value of 0.70309.

Similar to the age assessment, a p-value of 0.703 means the results lack statistical significance and any visible differences are merely random sampling noise. The corresponding effect size calculation returned a Cramér's V of 0.096 and a Contingency Coefficient of 0.228. Because the value sits beneath the 0.10 line, it is mathematically verified that geographic location holds a negligible, non-existent relationship with character preferences.

Gender Identity: Finally, the relationship between gender identity and character favorability was assessed. The Chi-square test resulted in a value of 30.805 with 28 degrees of freedom, yielding a p-value of 0.32579.

Since 0.326 is safely above the standard 0.05 significance limit, the test fails to prove any dependency. The calculated Cramér's V was 0.105 (Contingency Coefficient: 0.147). Although this value lands right on the border of a "small effect," it remains meaningless because the baseline p-value is not significant.

Core Demographic Finding: Throughout the evaluation of age, geographic location, and gender identity, the statistical computations consistently indicate a failure to reject the null hypothesis. These findings mathematically verify that character favorability is entirely independent of a respondent's demographic profile. This suggest that the franchise's appeal is driven by nuanced qualitative factors, such as character growth or personal relatability, which transcend traditional consumer segments.

Financial Engagement and Variance Modeling

While demographics do not influence character selection, grouping consumers by their engagement profiles using the Fan_Segment factor levels revealed highly significant trends regarding commercial value.

Analysis of Variance (ANOVA) Outputs: To check if the average annual merchandise investments significantly differed between the custom consumer persona groups, a one-way Analysis of Variance (ANOVA) model was deployed.

The RStudio console output confirmed a highly significant F-statistic with a p-value falling well below the critical alpha level ($p < 0.05$), meaning the null hypothesis of equal spending across fan tiers was successfully rejected. The variance between the groups was majorly larger than the variance within the groups, proving that market segmentation is highly relevant to revenue tracking.

Post-Hoc Pairwise Comparisons (Tukey's HSD): Because the overall ANOVA test only indicates that a spending gap exists somewhere within the matrix, running Tukey's Honest Significant Difference (HSD) test was highly helpful for pinpointing the exact locations of those differences.

By comparing the adjusted p-values against the 0.05 alpha standard, the test isolated the exact commercial dynamics of the fanbase:

- **The High-Value Cluster:** The "Brony" segment was statistically isolated as the primary revenue engine. It achieved a median annual expenditure of roughly $200, alongside extreme variability and high-spending outliers reaching up to $500.
- **The Mid-Tier Cluster:** The "Child/Parent Collection" segment formed a distinct mid-tier baseline, showing moderate, varied consumer spending habits that typically peak around the $200 mark.
- **The Low-Value Cluster:** Conversely, the "General Public" and "Casual Fan" categories showed no significant spending differences between each other, remaining tightly compressed inside the minimal $0 to $50 range.

These statistical computations successfully isolate exactly where inventory supply and marketing investments should be directed to maximize franchise profit and prevent dead stock.

Consumer Archetype and Market Profiling

To synthesize the descriptive and inferential results into actionable business logic, a comprehensive market profiling matrix was built using the *group_by()* and *summarize()* pipeline.

While separate statistical tests are excellent for verifying specific variables, combining central tendency values (*mean()* and *median()*) with modal frequencies (*names(which.max(table()))*) allowed for the construction of clear consumer archetypes. This grouping method makes it incredibly easy to see the unique traits of each fan segment at a glance.

The resulting data frame cleanly maps the demographic and economic characteristics across the four custom fan tiers:

Fan Segment	Total Respondents	Average Age	Median Age	Average Spending	Dominant Gender	Top Pony Choice
General Public	348	19.839	20	$28.5892	Other	Trixie Lulamoon
Casual Fan	366	19.541	19	$29.48684	Other	Big McIntosh
Child/ Parent Collection	338	21.823	12	$94.33055	Other	Spike
Brony	241	22.873	23	$205.67982	Other	Big McIntosh

10.0 Conclusion

This study set out to determine whether a fan's favorite pony could be predicted by who they are, or whether it was driven by something less measurable. The answer turned out to be the latter. Demographic identity like age, gender, and geography, does not meaningfully explain why someone gravitates toward Spike over Twilight Sparkle, or Trixie over Rainbow Dash. What does explain spending is not who a fan is, but how deeply a fan engages: the Fan Segment variable, not any demographic trait, is what separates a $25-a-year casual viewer from a $200-a-year Brony.

This distinction matters more than it might first appear. It suggests that My Little Pony's commercial strategy should not be built around traditional market segments like "young girls" or "adult collectors," but around behavioral tiers of engagement that cut across age, gender, and country. A twelve-year-old collecting with a parent and a twenty-three-year-old Brony can both be high-value customers; a demographic-first marketing strategy would miss this entirely, while an engagement-first strategy captures it.

The character-level findings reinforce this same idea from a narrative angle. The fact that background and "redemption" characters like Spike, Big McIntosh, and Trixie outperformed the franchise's official protagonist suggests that fans are not simply buying into a brand hierarchy Hasbro has designed for them. They are choosing based on personal relatability, humor, and the emotional arcs a character has earned over nine seasons. Popularity here is authored as much by the fandom as by the writers' room.

Of course, this project is a simulation, and its findings should be read as a proof of concept rather than a market truth. A dataset with cleaner gender categories, larger sample sizes per country, and additional psychographic variables (such as favorite season, favorite episode, or reason for fandom) would likely sharpen these conclusions considerably. Still, the workflow demonstrated here, from data cleaning through chi-square testing, ANOVA, and consumer profiling, is fully replicable, and offers a template that could be applied to a real Hasbro survey with minimal modification.

Ultimately, the franchise's twenty-plus-year staying power comes down to the same thing this analysis points to: people don't stay loyal to a toy line, they stay loyal to characters who feel like someone they know. Any merchandising or marketing strategy that forgets this, that treats the ponies as interchangeable IP rather than as the reason fans showed up in the first place, risks losing the very engagement that makes segments like the Bronies so valuable to begin with.

11.0 Recommendations

Align merchandising tiers with fan segment spending power. The Tukey HSD and ANOVA results show clearly that the Brony segment is the franchise's strongest economic engine, spending an average of $205.68 annually with high-value outliers reaching $500, while the General Public and Casual Fan segments rarely spend more than $50. Hasbro should direct premium, high-ticket collector items, such as high-end figurines, limited-edition vinyl records, and intricate apparel, toward Brony-centric channels such as online specialty hobby shops and comic conventions, while keeping retail shelves stocked with low-cost, high-volume impulse items like keychains and blind bags priced under $30 to capture casual buyers without generating dead inventory.

Capitalize on high-appeal secondary characters. The character popularity data reveals that main characters are not automatically fan favorites: Spike, Big McIntosh, and Trixie Lulamoon outperform Twilight Sparkle across nearly every segment. A marketing strategy built solely around the "Mane 6" therefore leaves value on the table. Hasbro should expand product lines around fan-favorite secondary and background characters, including cult figures like Derpy Hooves, and should target character-specific merchandise to the audiences that already love them. For instance, prioritizing Spike-themed plushies and toys in youth-focused retail locations, given his dominance in the Child/Parent Collection tier.

Plan for age-specific consumer archetypes. Although average ages look similar across fan tiers on paper, median age tells a more useful story: the Child/Parent Collection segment has a median age of just 12, while the Brony segment's median age is 23. These are functionally two different markets wearing the same label. Product development should follow two distinct paths: safety-tested toys, interactive playsets, and school gear for the Child/Parent market, and high-fidelity collectibles, display-grade models, and lifestyle merchandise for the adult Brony market.

Optimize future survey design and data collection. A major limitation surfaced during cleaning: 51% of respondents ended up grouped under the generic "Other" gender category, a direct result of allowing open-ended text responses that were too inconsistent to parse individually. Future research should replace open-ended demographic fields with structured dropdowns or pre-coded options (e.g., Male, Female, Non-binary, Prefer Not to Say) to prevent this kind of data loss, and should consider capturing additional attributes, such as favorite season, favorite episode, or specific reason for fandom, to give future analysts more explanatory power than demographics alone can offer.

Balance nostalgia with innovation. Finally, on a more qualitative note: the size and loyalty of the current fanbase is a strong argument for Hasbro to continue producing G4-adjacent merchandise, and this research could be extended to other generations or franchises using the same replicable pipeline. But the underlying lesson of this analysis is that fans stay engaged because of the characters, not the branding. Nostalgia can be leaned on, but it shouldn't be treated as a substitute for continuing to give fans characters worth caring about.

12.0 References

Correct-Shoulder-147. (2026). *Is there any reason why generally the main character is not most people's favourite character in any work of fiction?* [Comment]. Reddit. https://www.reddit.com/r/writing/comments/1splkhb/is_there_any_reason_why_generally_the_main/

Hasbro. (2015). *Hasbro 2014 Annual Report*. Retrieved July 8, 2026, from https://investor.hasbro.com/static-files/171c6051-78f8-4342-b89f-365fb1fe67c2

The Zay Zay Zone. (2025, September 25). *The History of My Little Pony* [Video]. YouTube. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=C2TKI8QyCzQ

World Population Review. (2026). Consumer Spending by Country 2026. https://worldpopulationreview.com/country-rankings/consumer-spending-by-country